LONG-TERM GOALS LIKE VIKSIT BHARAT SELDOM ENTHUSE VOTERS WITHOUT TANGIBLE SHORT-TERM MEASURES TO UPLIFT THEIR ECONOMIC STATUS. THAT IS WHAT TEAM MODI NEEDS TO WORK ON

the Ram temple in Ayodhya next year in January will mark another auspicious beginning to his campaign. Expect Hindutva to remain a mainstay of the BJP election campaign. The rules for the 2019 Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) may also be framed before March, as Union minister of state for home Ajay Kumar Mishra indicated during a recent trip to West Bengal. The Act enables the fast-tracking of citizenship to Hindu, Sikh, Parsi, Christian, Buddhist and Jain (but not Muslim) refugees from Pakistan, Afghanistan and Bangladesh who entered India before December 31, 2014, to escape religious persecution in their home countries (which they are required to prove—the putative reason for excluding Muslims). "The BJP will be searching for greenfield areas where it can win more seats," says Sethi. "And it will go about it with surgical precision, sending out MLAs from states where it is secure to other potential states to energise cadre and expand its support base. The idea will be to build from bottom-up." The party is also making a concerted effort to woo SCs/STs, who have 84 and 47 reserved seats, respectively, in the Lok Sabha. So much so that it has put one of its pet planks—the Uniform Civil Code (UCC)—on the back burner after several tribal groups protested saying it would impinge on their age-old customs.



THE ROAD TO 2024

Even the economic sentiment seems to be working in Modi's favour. Growth numbers are looking up and the stock market is booming, adding to the positivity around the Modi government. Never mind that the growth may be K-shaped, with the rich and the middle class getting richer and the poor seeing their incomes drop and job opportunities shrink. The frenzy around freebies during elections is evidence that people have begun relying on doles for sustenance, an indication that all is not well with the economy, something that should worry the BJP. That's why Modi, despite his aversion to giving freebies, may be forced to open government coffers to woo the voters. He has already announced the Rs 13,000 crore Vishwakarma scheme to support small business owners, especially traditional artisans and craftspeople, and offer them financial assistance of up to Rs 3 lakh. To support vulnerable tribal groups, he launched a Rs 24,000 crore welfare scheme in August, which includes housing, roads and tap water supply for them.

The state elections in the North won, Modi is already in battle mode for the general election in May. Perceptive political analysts like Tiwari discern a triple strategy. The first unfolded with Modi's massive drive to get his ministers and partymen to talk about his government's achievements in the past 10 years, of which he has plenty to showcase and which dovetail neatly with his philosophy of '*Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas, Sabka Prayaas*'. The second is not to benchmark his performance against his immediate predecessor's but with the pace of progress in the 67 years before he took over, to convey a sense of magnitude about what he has achieved. The third is to enunciate a vision that invokes hope and aspiration among various sections of society. Hence the dream of Viksit Bharat, a developed India, by 2047. The 25-year plan allows Modi to be a statesman with a long-term vision without having to commit to anything in the short run. Like doubling-the-farmers' income kind of promise he is still held to. But lofty long-term goals seldom enthuse voters without tangible short-term measures to uplift their economic status. That is something Team Modi needs to work on. But as Modi's popularity ratings continue to soar—rare for a leader serving his 10th consecutive year as prime minister—he is the clear frontrunner for a hat-trick in 2024. ■